the wherewithal to carry out a detailed investigation of listing requests. They allow the P-5 to drive the process. If all the P-5 are in agreement, the other ten members (who are also non-permanent members of the UNSC) concur or are induced to succumb to pressure. India's first attempt at listing Masood Azhar revealed that, logic apart, the interplay of relationships was much more important in determining the decisions of the committee. Three relationships were in play: India and China, China and Pakistan, and China and the United States of America.

India–China relations had improved in several areas since the year 2000. However, the relationship still continued to be plagued by distrust due to historical problems that had remained unresolved, and new problems such as China's behaviour in the NSG during the Indo–US nuclear deal and the question of 'stapled' visas for Indian citizens born in Arunachal Pradesh and Jammu and Kashmir. The growing proximity of Pakistan to China in the first decade of the twenty-first century was a further factor in the trust deficit between India and China. Nevertheless, China had begun a Joint Working Group on Counter-Terrorism with India. Its position in public forums on terrorism, including on the Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism, was more aligned to that of India than of the West. Due to internal political problems in Pakistan, the Kashmir Question had also taken a back seat and China did not have to publicly take a stand on this problem. Therefore, in 2009–2010, China was able to block the listing of Masood Azhar relatively easily and without any significant fallout in bilateral ties with India.

Pakistan had been an important relationship for China since the early 1960s. Over time, this relationship had transformed itself into a strategic alliance with India as the most important target, despite protestations by China to the contrary. By the